

The Law Society

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THE HERITAGE of FLEET STREET

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The Law Society has been welcoming people into its Grade II* listed building at 113 Chancery Lane since 1831. The society is the professional body for solicitors in England and Wales, and its vision is to promote, protect and support solicitors, the rule of law and justice in England and Wales.

The Law Society's motto is "We preserve the laws and legal rights" for all. This is something the Law Society acts on daily. It leads the campaign for access to free legal advice, being the first to administer Legal Aid following the Rushcliffe Committee report of 1945, and the fight for justice for everyone. The Society leads in diversifying the profession with its Diversity Access Scheme, encouraging those from less advantaged backgrounds to take up a career as a solicitor via a unique scholarship programme.

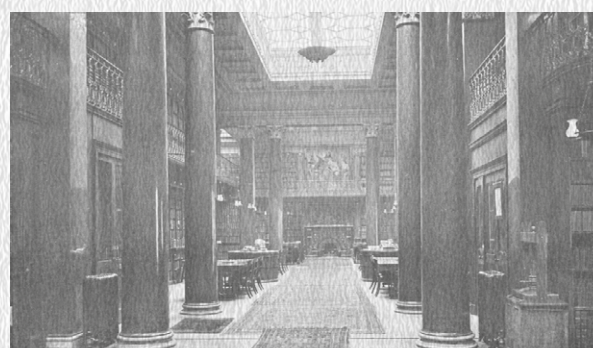
In 1823 Bryan Holme gathered a group of prominent solicitors in Serle's coffee house and issued a prospectus to source subscribers to buy shares to enable the building of a large room or hall with a library of law and other subjects, a dining-club and offices. This was devised to promote and improve the reputation of the solicitor profession through sharing knowledge and improving education. The issuing of shares succeeded. Some £25,000 was raised and a site acquired for a Hall in Chancery Lane.

In the archive is held a catalogue of the "valuable building material" that was sold when this original site was cleared. This included two "spacious dwelling" houses, warehouses and outbuildings that jostled for space in Chancery Lane.

The Law Society was founded on 2 June 1825 at Serle's. It was originally called The Society of Attorneys, Solicitors, Proctors and others not being Barristers, practising in the Courts of Law and Equity of the United Kingdom. The name was changed to the more succinct The Law Society in 1903. Initially there were 292 members.



Chancery Lane Entrance



The Library - 1904

Lewis Vulliamy, a pupil of Sir Robert Smirke, the architect of the British Museum, won the architectural competition to build the Hall. The influence of Sir Robert can be seen in the portico entrance to the Hall, with echoes of the frontage of the British Museum. You need to view the building from the other side of the street to see how it was originally envisioned, an imposing statement building underlining the importance of the solicitor profession. Lewis Vulliamy's travels around Greece, Italy and Asia Minor between 1818–1822 can also be seen in the designs of the interior.

Lewis was in some respects the odd one out in his family, coming from a long line of renowned clockmakers; his brother Benjamin was the King's clockmaker by Royal Appointment in 1773, and the Hall has six of Benjamin's clocks around

its rooms. Benjamin's grandson, George, was also an architect and designed, among other things, the pedestal and sphinxes for Cleopatra's Needle and the camel-sided benches along the Embankment.

The first Annual General Meeting of The Law Society was held in the Reading Room in 1831, and the building formally opened in 1832. The Law Society Hall continued to expand when other properties became available next to the site, to accommodate its growing membership and staff, and there are six distinct phases in its building history from 1831-1901. These include designs and work by such esteemed architects as Charles Holden, recognised as one of the greatest architects of his generation, and Philip Charles Hardwick, who was involved in the design of St Bartholomew's Hospital and the Bank of England.

A striking feature of this building is its architecture, both exterior and interiors, including its Library for members, the Common Room and Reading Room (as described on the next page).

The Hall is also unique as it has a restaurant and bar. Six Clerks is a reminder of the original Six Clerks' Office that was in this location between 1622 and 1778. Here, the officers of the Court of Chancery would once gather.